



STARTPAD TOOLKIT · NO. 01

The Readiness Audit

Four requirements, scored honestly, in about an hour. It tells you which one to spend the next month on and it will not flatter you.

One hour · Print this and write on it

startpad.me

Met, or not met. There is no partly.

This audit is only useful if it is uncomfortable. Every requirement below is scored against evidence somebody else could check, not against how confident you feel. A generous score costs you a month you spend building the wrong thing.

01 Print it, or fill it on screen

Every field is a real field. Writing the answer down is part of the exercise — an answer you can only say out loud is not yet an answer.

02 Answer from evidence, not memory

Where a field asks for a number, go and count it. Where it asks for a name, use the actual name. “Several people” scores zero.

03 Score at the end, not as you go

Scoring each section as you write it pulls the later answers toward the total you want. Fill in all four first, then score.

MISSION 01

MISSION 15



Where this sits. This is the work of missions 01 and 02. The result tells you which of the missions after them is worth your month.

One hour, once

This is not a document to keep updating. Do it once, act on the weakest requirement for a month, then do it again from a blank copy and compare. The gap between the two copies is the only progress measure that matters here.

What is actually being asked.

Programmes vary enormously in what they fund and almost not at all in what they screen for. The four below are the screen, in the order they are usually applied. Failing the first makes the other three irrelevant, which is why the audit runs in this order.

THE REQUIREMENT		WHAT A READER IS CHECKING
01	A named problem, and a named person who has it	That you can describe one person, not a market, and say what goes wrong for them today.
02	Evidence you did not make up	That something in your answer could be verified without contacting you.
03	Something that exists	That you have built or run something, however small and however manual.
04	A reason it is you	That there is an access, skill or history that makes you a better bet than the next applicant.

Each requirement below is scored **0 to 5**. The anchors are printed next to the scale so the number means the same thing every time you do this. Twenty is the maximum and nobody starting out scores it.

A named problem, and a named person who has it

The most common first-screen failure is a problem described at the level of a population. “Young people in Egypt struggle to find work” is a headline, not a problem statement. A problem statement names somebody and says what specifically goes wrong for them, when, and what it costs them.

Worksheet 1A · The person

REQUIREMENT 01

Write about one real person you have actually met. If you cannot, that is the finding, and the score is zero.

Their name, or initials if you prefer

A real person. Not a persona and not a composite.

What they do, in one line

The last time this problem happened to them, and what happened

A specific occasion with a date, not a general tendency.

What it cost them — money, hours, or an outcome they lost

What they do about it today, without you

Everyone already does something. The something is your real competitor.

Worksheet 1B · The problem statement

REQUIREMENT 01

Now write it as one sentence a stranger could repeat back to you correctly.

When [person] is [situation], they [what goes wrong], which costs them [cost]. Today they [current workaround].

YOUR SCORE

0-1

No named person, or the problem is stated at population level.

2-3

A named person exists, but the problem is described in general terms.

4

One person, one occasion, a cost you can state.

5

The above, and they told you, unprompted, before you asked.

Score requirement 01. Write your score in the box on the scoring page. The jump from 3 to 4 is the whole requirement: a general truth becomes a specific incident.

Evidence you did not make up

This is the requirement founders most often believe they have met. The test is simple and it is not about how convinced you are: could somebody check your answer without contacting you, and would what they found match what you said?

COUNTS	DOES NOT COUNT
Conversations, dated, with who said what	"Everyone I spoke to loved it"
A waiting list with real names on it	A survey your friends answered
Money taken before the thing existed	A market size from a consultancy report
A log from a service you ran by hand	Sign-ups to a page offering something free
A supplier or partner who agreed in writing	A letter of intent that binds nobody

The line is verifiability, not enthusiasm. Everything on the right can be true and still prove nothing, because it survives regardless of whether the problem is real.

Worksheet 2A - Count it

REQUIREMENT 02

Numbers only. If you have to estimate, the answer is zero — go and count it before you fill this in.

People you have spoken to about this problem, in person or on a call

Not messages. A conversation where they talked more than you did.

Of those, how many raised the problem before you described it

This is the single most predictive number on the page.

People who have given you something — money, a commitment, their time on a waiting list

The date of your most recent conversation

Evidence more than three months old is history, not evidence.

Worksheet 2B · The strongest single piece

REQUIREMENT 02

One piece of evidence, described so a stranger could go and verify it.

What it is

Who could confirm it, and how they would be reached

If the answer is “only me”, it is not evidence yet.

What it would take to make it stronger this month

YOUR SCORE

0-1

Nothing countable, or evidence you produced yourself.

2-3

Real conversations, but you raised the problem every time.

4

Ten or more, several of whom raised it unprompted.

5

The above, plus somebody gave you money, time or a commitment.

Score requirement 02. Unprompted mentions and money are the two signals that cannot be manufactured by asking nicely.

Something that exists

This requirement is widely misread as “a working product”. It is not. What a reader wants to know is whether you convert intent into an artefact, because most people never do. A spreadsheet you run by hand for four real users clears this bar. A beautiful deck does not.

Worksheet 3 · What exists

REQUIREMENT 03

What you have built or run, in one line

Manual counts. Paper counts. A group chat you moderate counts.

How many people other than you have used it, and when

What it does today that it did not do a month ago

Where a stranger could see it or try it

A link, a file, a place. Not a description.

YOUR SCORE

0-1	2-3	4	5
Nothing exists outside documents and conversations.	Something exists but only you have used it.	Real people other than you have used it at least once.	People came back to it without being asked.

Score requirement 03. The bar is use by somebody else, not polish. A rough thing five people used beats a finished thing nobody has touched.

A reason it is you

The weakest possible answer is enthusiasm, because every applicant has it. The strongest is something a competitor would have to spend real time or money to acquire: access to the people with the problem, a skill that is scarce where you are, or a history with the problem that gives you judgement nobody can look up.

Worksheet 4 · The unfair part

REQUIREMENT 04

Access you have that a stranger does not — to customers, a place, a network, data

A skill you have that is genuinely scarce in this market

Your history with this problem

Having lived it counts for a great deal. Say so plainly if you have.

How long it would take a well-funded stranger to get what you have

If the answer is under a month, this is not yet an advantage.

YOUR SCORE

0-1	2-3	4	5
Interest and commitment, which everyone has.	A relevant skill or background, but nothing hard to acquire.	Access or a history a stranger would need months to build.	The above, and it is already producing results you can point at.

Score requirement 04. The time-to-copy question at the bottom of the worksheet is the score. Everything else is context for it.

Add the four. Read the band. Do not negotiate.

Your score	ALL FOUR REQUIREMENTS
01 A named problem and a named person / 5	
02 Evidence you did not make up / 5	
03 Something that exists / 5	
04 A reason it is you / 5	
Total / 20	
And the date. You will want it when you do this again.	

YOUR SCORE

0-6	7-12	13-16	17-20
Applying now wastes the application. Work on your lowest requirement for one month.	One real gap. You know which it is — it is the lowest number on your sheet.	Applying is reasonable. Close the lowest requirement while you wait to hear.	Apply, and to more than one place. Your constraint is no longer readiness.

The bands. They are deliberately blunt. A score of twelve is not “almost thirteen” — it is one gap, and the gap has a name.

What to do with the result

Take the **lowest** of your four scores, not the total. The total tells you whether to apply; the lowest score tells you what to do tomorrow. A founder who spends a month on their weakest requirement almost always moves further than one who spends it on their strongest.

YOUR LOWEST SCORE IS	SPEND THE MONTH ON	THE COMPANION RESOURCE
Requirement 01	Twenty conversations with people who have the problem, and one problem statement that survives them	Toolkit 02 — The Evidence Toolkit

YOUR LOWEST SCORE IS	SPEND THE MONTH ON	THE COMPANION RESOURCE
Requirement 02	Counting, dating and recording what you already have, then adding to it deliberately	Toolkit 02 — The Evidence Toolkit
Requirement 03	Running the service by hand for ten people, with no product built	Toolkit 03 — The Manual MVP
Requirement 04	Finding the access or skill you already have and making it produce something visible	Toolkit 05 — The Application File

SAY	NEVER SAY
You are missing two of the four.	You've got this.
Requirement 02 is where most people stall.	Your journey starts here.
Twelve out of twenty, dated 14 March.	You're nearly there.
You finished it. We just kept the file.	We built a founder.

Do this again in a month from a blank copy. Do not look at the old one until the new one is finished — comparing as you write is how a score stops being honest.



StartPad tells you the truth about whether you are ready, gets you ready, and gives you the proof.

What it is

A founder-readiness platform for Egypt and the wider MENA region. It takes a young person who has an idea and no company, moves them through fifteen structured missions, and turns them into someone the ecosystem will take seriously — then issues verifiable proof of that.

It is not a course platform, not an education brand and not a youth club. Nothing here is graded. Every mission ends in an artefact you own.

Three moves, always in this order

TRUTH **Where you actually stand**

Measured against what programmes actually ask for, stated plainly, before any encouragement.

READINESS **Fifteen structured missions**

They close the specific gaps the assessment found, in the order that matters. A route, not a curriculum.

PROOF **A verifiable credential**

The ecosystem can check it without asking you. You apply with a file, not a hope.

On your idea

StartPad earns when a founder gets into somewhere — an accelerator, a programme, a room. Taking a founder's idea would end that. Work submitted to a mission is sealed and timestamped to the person who submitted it, and the seal is the product.

Nothing in this document asks you to give anything up to use it. It is yours to fill in, print, and hand to whoever needs to see it.

startpad.me

Start with the readiness assessment. It is free and it takes about twenty minutes.